

THE IGNITING STUDIO

The *Roughcut* Skill

RAW FOOTAGE → CAPCUT PROJECT. IN MINUTES.

A Claude Code skill that listens to your raw video, removes silences, stutters and retakes, writes a hook, and drops a finished CapCut project right into your drafts. You just review and publish.

[THEIGNITINGSTUDIO.COM](https://theignitingstudio.com)

1. What it does

You point it at a raw video file. Claude reads what you said, finds every dead spot, stutter, false start and repeated take, picks a hook for you, and writes a CapCut project ready to open and review.

No rendering. No exporting. No manual cutting. **You open CapCut and your edit is already there.**

HOW IT WORKS

Your raw video file

Any format: MP4, MOV, MKV, WebM, AVI

Normalize the source

Re-encoded once into a clean canonical format

Detect silence + transcribe audio

Word-level timestamps, accurate to the millisecond

Claude reads the transcript

Finds stutters, retakes, fillers, false starts

Claude writes 5 hook options

Tailored to what you actually said in the video

Build the CapCut project

Cuts, hook overlay, timeline, ready to play

Open in CapCut and publish

No exporting, no re-rendering — just review

2. What you need before starting

Don't worry — Claude Code does most of the heavy lifting for you. The first time you run the skill, it checks what's installed on your machine and tells you exactly what (if anything) is missing.

The only things **you** have to do once, by hand:

- **Install Claude Code** — the CLI/desktop app from Anthropic. (claude.ai/claude-code)
- **Make sure CapCut is installed** on your computer. The free desktop app from capcut.com.
- **Sign up for two free API keys** — they let Claude transcribe your audio. Both have generous free tiers (you'll likely never hit them).

FREE API KEYS YOU NEED

- **AssemblyAI** — sign up at assemblyai.com, copy your API key from the dashboard. (Free tier covers ~5 hours of video per month.)
- **Google Gemini** — go to aistudio.google.com/app/apikey, click "Create API key", copy it. (Generous free tier.)

WHAT CLAUDE CODE HANDLES FOR YOU

When you first run the skill, Claude Code will check whether **Node.js** and **FFmpeg** are installed on your computer. If they're missing, it will tell you the exact one-line command to install them on your platform. It will also run `npm install` automatically the first time. You don't have to memorize anything.

3. One-time setup

About five minutes total, mostly waiting on downloads.

- 1 **Install Claude Code** from claude.ai/claude-code. Sign in with your Claude account.
- 2 **Download the `igniting-roughcut` folder** (the one this guide came with). Put it somewhere stable on your computer — for example, `~/Tools/igniting-roughcut` on Mac or `C:\Tools\igniting-roughcut` on Windows.

- 3 **Sign up for the two free API keys** (AssemblyAI and Google Gemini — links above). Copy each key somewhere safe.
- 4 **Open the folder in Claude Code** — open Claude Code, and tell it to use the folder you just downloaded as its working directory.
- 5 **Tell Claude to set up the skill.** Say something like: *"set up the roughcut skill — check what's installed and walk me through what I need to add."* Claude will check Node, FFmpeg, the dependencies, and then ask you to put your two API keys into the `.env` file.
- 6 **Save your API keys to `.env`** when Claude asks. Open `.env.example` in any text editor, save it as `.env` in the same folder, and paste your keys where the placeholders are.

PRIVACY & SECURITY — IMPORTANT

Never paste your API keys into the chat with Claude. Always save them inside the `.env` file. The file is automatically excluded from anything that gets shared and never leaves your computer. Claude reads the keys directly from disk when it runs the pipeline — it never sees them as text in chat, so they stay private.

That's it. You won't need to do any of this again.

4. Using it on a video

Once setup is done, this is the entire workflow every time:

- 1 **Put your raw video somewhere**
Any folder works — for example, `~/Videos/raw/my-take.mp4`. Format doesn't matter (MP4, MOV, MKV, WebM and AVI all work).

2 Open Claude Code in the folder with your video

Just navigate to that folder and start a Claude Code session there — Claude will be able to see the file.

3 Tell Claude to roughcut it

Say *"use the roughcut skill on my-take.mp4"*. Or just *"roughcut my video"* — Claude will scan the folder and ask which video if there are several.

4 Wait while Claude analyzes (1–3 min the first time per video)

Claude will normalize the source video, transcribe the audio, and read the transcript looking for things to cut. Re-runs on the same video are instant after that.

5 Pick your hook from the 5 suggestions

Claude shows you stats (how much was silence, how much speech) and 5 short hook text options based on what you actually said. Type the number you like — or pick "6: write your own".

6 Open CapCut

Your edit is in the drafts list, named `<videoname>-roughcut` . Watch it through. Publish.

▲

5. What gets removed

Claude reads your transcript and looks for things that don't belong:

Silences

Stutters

False starts

Standalone fillers

Repeated takes

Trailing thoughts

Self-corrections

It will **not** remove ums or uhs that flow with natural speech, content you said only once, or anything ambiguous. Claude is conservative — when in doubt, it keeps the audio. **You're always in the driver's seat:** if you want it to keep or cut something specific, just tell Claude and it will rebuild the project.

PRO TIP

If you don't love the first version, just tell Claude what you'd change in plain English. *"Don't cut the part where I say X"* or *"also remove the long pause around the 30 second mark"*. Claude will adjust and rebuild — your old version stays in CapCut so nothing is lost.

6. Frequently asked

Does it modify my original video file?

No. Your original file is never touched. The pipeline writes a normalized copy into a temporary folder and a new CapCut project into your CapCut drafts folder.

Where do my API keys live?

Only in the `.env` file in the skill folder, on your machine. They are never sent to Claude in chat, never uploaded anywhere except directly to AssemblyAI and Google when transcription happens.

Does the AssemblyAI free tier really cover my usage?

The free tier gives you about five hours of audio per month. Most short-form creators don't come close to that.

Why does the first run take a few minutes?

Two reasons: (1) the source video is normalized once into a clean canonical format so all the downstream tools agree on the timeline, and (2) AssemblyAI needs to process the audio and return word timestamps. After the first run, both are cached and re-runs are instant.

Mac or Windows?

Both. CapCut is supported on both, and the skill auto-detects where your CapCut drafts folder lives on each platform.

What if it cuts something I wanted to keep?

Just tell Claude. *"Don't cut the part where I say X"* — Claude will rebuild the project under a new name. Your old version is still there in CapCut, so you can compare.

7. Want to make it even better?

The whole skill is open source code in the folder you downloaded. If you're curious or technical, you can crack it open and tinker. The code is short, well-commented, and Claude Code itself is the perfect copilot for modifying it.

FOR THE CURIOUS

Hack on it. Make it yours.

Here are a few ideas you could try, just by asking Claude to do them for you inside the folder:

- **Tweak the cut style.** "Be more aggressive about cutting silences" or "leave more breathing room between sentences."
- **Change the hook style.** Tell Claude to update the hook generation rules in `CLAUDE.md` — different templates, different lengths, different tone.
- **Add captions.** Wire the AssemblyAI word transcript into CapCut text segments to get auto-generated subtitles.
- **Change the layout.** Output 16:9 instead of 9:16 by tweaking the canvas dimensions in the builder.
- **Add B-roll.** Have Claude detect topic-relevant moments in your transcript and slot in B-roll clips automatically.

Just open the folder in Claude Code and ask. The skill is yours to modify — and Claude can guide you through the changes step by step, even if you don't write code.

COMING SOON — DON'T MISS OUT

The full CapCut edit product is on the way.

This roughcut skill is just the warm-up. We're shipping the full thing — a complete AI editor that takes your raw footage and produces a polished, ready-to-publish CapCut project. Way more than silences and hooks.

Imagine: **auto-generated captions, hook text, B-roll matched to what you're saying, screen-share overlays, motion graphics, greenscreen backgrounds, split-screen layouts, intro and outro** — all built around your actual content, end to end. You record once. The editor does the rest.

Follow [@the.igniting.studio](https://twitter.com/theignitingstudio) to be the first to know when it drops. You don't want to miss this.

THE IGNITING STUDIO

Built by a real studio running on Claude Code, sharing what we learn along the way.

theignitingstudio.com